a similar anti-migrant movement was started by the Kannada Chaluvaligars in Bangalore against the other south Indian migrants in the city. Today, a similar mantle is donned by the Karnataka Rakshana Vedike. A few other states witnessed agitations at different levels and intensities, and they would also be characterized by demands for the protection of jobs for locals, changes in the language of signboards and occasional violence.

In Assam, however, the ‘sons of the soil’ movement was literally an SOS agitation, leading to violence at a heightened level. As forewarned by I.G. Patel’s friend in the previous chapter, the historic migration of Bengali Muslims towards Assam in the Northeast continued after the liberation of Bangladesh in 1971, leading to tensions on the basis of region, religion, language and nationality, all rolled together. To understand the special case of anti-migrant sentiments in Assam, one needs to go back to the 19th century.

Assam in 19th century colonial India was a part of the Bengal Presidency and included most of the north-east area of the Indian subcontinent. The British conquered the Ahom kingdoms in the 1820s, ending six centuries of their rule that had earlier held out even against the rampaging Mughals. Since then, Assam became a frontier area for massive settlement, to occupy land, work in tea gardens and oil fields, start new businesses and initiate modern professions and the bureaucracy. Since the second half of the 19th century, it witnessed a migration-led demographic boom that lasted for nearly a century. Between 1901 and 1971, it was the fastest growing area of the subcontinent, growing from around 3 million to nearly 15 million.[49] Assam was earlier an important part of the Great Indian Migration Wave but, over time, migrations became more gender-balanced and permanent. Tribals from central India migrated to the tea gardens, Bengali Hindus occupied the bureaucracy and urban centres, Bengali Muslims from Mymensingh settled as peasants after clearing forest lands, Biharis and Nepalis worked as labourers in assorted jobs, and the Marwaris and Punjabis went as traders. In the early 20th century, over a fifth of Assam’s population was born outside, but the share of migrants fell to around 10 per cent in the next five decades. In 1971, nearly a third of the population spoke